

EU Institutions at a Glance

Who does what in the European Union

A short guide to the seven EU institutions, written for readers who want a clear overview without specialist terminology.

THE FIRST DISTINCTION TO REMEMBER

The European Council is not the Council of the EU

European Council = national leaders setting political direction

Council of the EU = national ministers negotiating and adopting laws

Independent educational resource. Not an official EU publication.

Information checked against official EU sources listed on page 5.

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The four names you will hear most often

These institutions have different roles in setting priorities, proposing laws, adopting laws and overseeing how the EU works.

- 1**

European Commission

PROPOSES AND IMPLEMENTS

The Commission proposes most new EU laws and policies. It also manages EU policies and funding, monitors how EU law is applied and manages the EU budget.
(European Commission, n.d.)
- 2**

European Parliament

REPRESENTS CITIZENS

The Parliament is directly elected by EU citizens. It adopts legislation together with the Council of the EU under the ordinary legislative procedure, shares responsibility for the annual EU budget and scrutinises the work of other EU institutions.
(European Parliament, n.d.)
- 3**

Council of the European Union

REPRESENTS GOVERNMENTS

National ministers from the 27 EU countries meet in the Council. They negotiate and adopt EU laws, usually together with Parliament, coordinate policies and share responsibility for the EU budget.
(Council of the European Union, n.d.)
- 4**

European Council

SETS POLITICAL DIRECTION

The heads of state or government of the 27 EU countries meet here with the Presidents of the European Council and European Commission. The European Council defines the EU's overall political direction and priorities. It does not negotiate or adopt EU laws.
(European Council, 2026)

A useful shortcut

Commission proposes | Parliament + Council adopt | European Council sets direction

Law, the euro and public money

The EU has seven institutions in total. These three have specialised judicial, monetary and audit roles.

COURT OF JUSTICE OF THE EUROPEAN UNION

Interpreting and enforcing EU law

The Court of Justice of the European Union interprets EU law and helps ensure that it is applied in the same way across the EU. It reviews the legality of EU acts and answers questions on EU law referred by national courts.

(Court of Justice of the European Union, n.d.)

EUROPEAN CENTRAL BANK

Monetary policy for the euro area

The ECB is the central bank of the euro area. Its primary objective is price stability. The ECB's Governing Council aims for 2% inflation over the medium term. The ECB also has important responsibilities for banking supervision.

(European Central Bank, n.d.)

EUROPEAN COURT OF AUDITORS

Independent audit of EU finances

The European Court of Auditors is the EU's external auditor. It carries out independent audits on EU action and financial management. Despite its name, it is not a court that decides legal cases.

(European Court of Auditors, n.d.)

A common route from proposal to EU law

The ordinary legislative procedure is the most common EU law-making procedure and applies to the vast majority of EU policy areas. Around 95% of EU legislation is adopted through it (Council of the European Union, 2026).

1

Political direction

The European Council sets broad priorities. It does not adopt the law itself.

(European Council, 2026)

2

Proposal

The European Commission prepares and proposes a new EU law.

(European Commission, n.d.; Council of the European Union, 2026)

3

Examination and negotiation

Parliament and the Council examine the proposal, may amend it and negotiate until both can agree.

(European Parliament, n.d.; Council of the European Union, 2026)

4

Adoption

When Parliament and the Council agree on the same final text, the legislative act is adopted.

(Council of the European Union, 2026)

QUICK REFERENCE

Four names, four different jobs

European Council	National leaders	Sets political direction
Council of the EU	National ministers	Adopts laws with Parliament
European Parliament	Directly elected MEPs	Adopts laws with the Council
European Commission	Commissioners and EU administration	Proposes most laws and implements policy

Note: special legislative procedures also exist. This briefing focuses on the ordinary legislative procedure.

References

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